The trigger rate is restated at 6.5 per cent

Determination 2027/1 of the Government Statistician under section 9 of the Regional Employment Support Act 2021. Statistics Office, 3 February 2027.

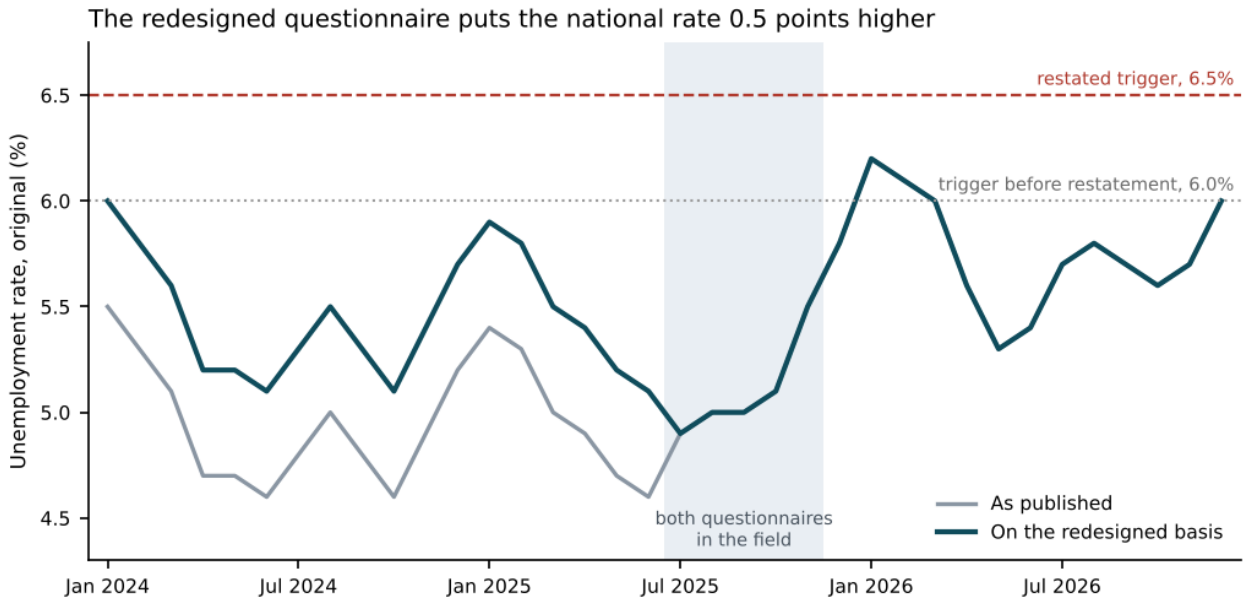
Determination

The Labour Force Survey moved to its redesigned questionnaire with the rotation groups replaced from July 2025, and every rotation group has answered it since December 2025. With the redesigned questionnaire in full use, the national unemployment rate the survey publishes is 0.5 percentage points higher than the previous questionnaire would have published for the same months. Under section 9(2) the trigger rate of 6.0 per cent is restated at 6.5 per cent, and it applies to the designation that takes effect on 1 April 2027 and to every later one.

On their twelve-month averages for 2026, every month of them measured on the redesigned questionnaire, four regions are at or above the restated trigger: Eastern Ranges, Western Coast, River Delta and Highlands.

How the change was measured

From July to November 2025 the dwellings entering the sample answered the redesigned questionnaire while the dwellings already in it finished on the previous one, so in each of those months the two questionnaires were answered by dwellings at different interviews: the redesign by dwellings on their first few, the previous questionnaire by dwellings on their last. A first interview, conducted face to face, has always found more people looking for work than the telephone interviews after it. The change was therefore read interview by interview: each interview number on the redesigned questionnaire against the same interview number on the previous questionnaire in the months before July 2025, month and region held fixed. The redesign lowers the rate at a first interview and raises it at the second to sixth, where dependent interviewing applies, and the change in the published rate is the average of the six interview effects, as the published estimate averages the six rotation groups.



Months before July 2025 restated by the change as determined; July to November 2025, with both questionnaires in the field, as published. Source: Labour Force Survey estimation cells (CAI 2014 and ICS) and the December 2026 release.

Regions designated for 2027

Region	Twelve-month average, 2026 (%)	Designated
01 Capital	4.32	No
02 Harbour	5.38	No
03 North Coast	6.44	No
04 Inland Plains	6.21	No
05 Eastern Ranges	**6.58**	**Yes**
06 Southern Valleys	4.90	No
07 Western Coast	**6.64**	**Yes**
08 River Delta	**7.44**	**Yes**
09 Highlands	**8.32**	**Yes**

Averages are the means of the twelve monthly rates published to one decimal place (section 3).

The survey behind the 2026 rates

In the fourth quarter of 2026 the survey interviewed 88,040 dwellings, each counted once whatever the number of its interviews in the quarter; a dwelling counts when it gave a full or a partial interview.

Region	Responding dwellings, October to December 2026
01 Capital	14,827
02 Harbour	11,749
03 North Coast	9,532
04 Inland Plains	10,842
05 Eastern Ranges	7,981
06 Southern Valleys	9,007
07 Western Coast	7,532
08 River Delta	10,008
09 Highlands	6,562
All regions	88,040

Jared Elliott
Government Statistician